but 30 new FOBs have sprung up in 2024 alone. In keeping with Shah's policy of "ruthlessly dealing with gun-toting Naxals", these FOBs are armed with the latest equipment that has helped the forces outgun and outrange Naxalite arms. Besides Bulgarian-made AK series assault rifles, some of which have Under Barrel Grenade Launchers attached to them, Tavors and JVPC carbines, the forces have an array of area dominance weapons such as Carl Gustav 84 mm rocket launchers, 51 and 81 mm mortars, thermal imaging scopes as well as night vision equipment.

The newest addition to the forces' arsenal is WhAP or the Wheeled Armoured Platform, jointly designed by Tata Advanced Systems and the Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO). An armoured troop carrier, it has weapons control inside the vehicle and anti-mine abilities. This platform has helped the forces take the battle to the Naxals when under attack. Last year, when Naxals attacked the CRPF camp in Tekulagudem in Telangana, second-in-command S.S. Haokip commandeered the WhAP that used its MMGs to open fire at the huddled insurgents. This was the first time the Naxals had witnessed a WhAP in action, forcing them to beat a hasty retreat.

Equally game-changing has been the Modi government's infusion of state-of-the-art surveillance technology, especially for intelligence-gathering and analysis. Each FOB is equipped with NETRA 3 and Bharat drones that have a range of 5 km and endurance of 60 minutes with multiple battery back-up. The drones can be flown out of a 10m x 10m space and send back razor-sharp images in real time to a screen at the base. Before embarking on an operation, forces fly the drones ahead of them, mapping the topography and the presence of any Naxals. Infrared capabilities for nighttime operations can discern humans from animal movement. As Choudhary puts it, "There is nowhere for our adversary to hide now and, for the first time after many years, the Naxals are truly on the run."

Performing the most critical job of being eyes in the sky are the Heron UAVs (unmanned aerial vehicles), with a service ceiling of 35,000 feet and an endurance of 10 hours. Flying out of nearby airstrips, the Herons collect images of the affected area and pick up conversations on wireless and cellphones. The data is shared with security personnel who corroborate it with ground intelligence. A conversation, a phone call or fire from an uninhabited point on the map suggest the presence of rebels. Recent operations have been pinpointed and hugely successful mainly due to the sharing of technical intelligence or Techint between the Union government and state government agencies, says Amit Kumar, the CRPF's additional director general for the central zone.

Accurate human intelligence or Humint has started flowing in with locals, who know the terrain well, being recruited as District Reserve Guards (DRG) and the newly formed



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"Our objective is to dismantle the leadership and ensure no fresh Maoist cases are reported. We want to end the Maoist ability to perpetuate violence"

— Sundarraj P., *IG, Chhattisgarh Police*

Bastariya Battalion. In addition, many of the 7,500 Naxals who have surrendered since 2014 have joined these forces, providing information on how the Naxals operate and their hideouts (see *The Tip of the Spear*). As a result of these measures, operations have intensified and 305 Naxals were eliminated in Chhattisgarh in the past 15 months, and 217 in the Bastar division in 2024 alone—the highest ever for any year since the history of insurgency in the state. Meanwhile, in the areas cleared of Naxals, Fortified Police Stations manned by the Chhattisgarh police have been set up to maintain dominance. That 612 stations have come up in the past decade across Naxal-affected states is proof of the extent of the turf gained.

In another significant measure, the central and state governments concerned in Naxal areas have squeezed the funds